EXECUTIVE RESEARCH REPORT

Replacing the ThinkPad E15

Which 16-inch laptop meets the voice-note requirements, what a basic and a stretch spec cost, and where to buy

Claude for Daniel Rosehill · 2026-11-02

Researched by	Claude Code · Opus 5.5 (claude-opus-5-5), agents Sonnet 5.5 (claude-sonnet-5-5)
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Requested by	Daniel Rosehill, for Laptop-Search-1126 (a public demo of voice note → agent research → PDF)

Summary

The Lenovo ThinkPad T16 Gen 5 is the best fit. It is the only model whose manufacturer spec sheet confirms every core requirement: 64 GB, 2 TB, a 5G modem with eSIM, Wi-Fi 7, USB-C charging, a numeric keypad to remap as macro keys, and a 10/10 iFixit repairability score. A basic spec (32 GB, 2 TB) costs about ₪11,200–12,400 in Israel today: a 32 GB / 1 TB unit from Zap's listings plus a 2 TB SSD fitted locally. A stretch spec (64 GB, 2 TB) costs about ₪15,000–20,500, depending on whether the two-slot AMD version is sold in Israel. Buy in Israel. Once Israeli VAT is added, US list prices come to about the same, and Lenovo's international warranty only covers machine types that are also sold in Israel. Budget ₪12,500 for the basic spec and ₪16,000 for the stretch spec. Confirm before ordering that the chosen Israeli SKU actually has the 5G/eSIM module.

1 Bottom line

Buy a ThinkPad T16 Gen 5 in Israel, and budget ₪12,500 for the basic spec or ₪16,000 for the stretch spec. Confidence is medium. The specs come from Lenovo's own spec sheets, which I checked directly [1][2]. The prices are reseller asking prices on Zap from one day [3][4]. Four things would change the answer:

- **5G/eSIM availability.** If no Israeli T16 Gen 5 SKU comes with the 5G/eSIM module, the choice moves to the HP EliteBook 8 G1i 16. HP's spec sheet confirms the module, but it must be chosen at purchase [5].
- **The AMD version.** If the T16 Gen 5 AMD (two SODIMM slots) is sold in Israel, it is the better buy. RAM can then be added later, without replacing the single LPCAMM2 module the Intel version has [2][1].
- **Local LLMs.** If running local models of 30B parameters or more becomes a real goal, neither machine is enough. That needs an AMD Strix Halo laptop with up to 128 GB of unified memory, which this research did not price [6].

- **Framework.** If Framework starts shipping to Israel with a cellular option, the Framework Laptop 16 becomes the best match on macro keys and repairability. Neither is the case now [7].

2 Key findings

Finding	Confidence	Sources
The ThinkPad T16 Gen 5 meets every tier-1 item on Lenovo's spec sheet: up to 64 GB (Intel) or 96 GB (AMD), a 2 TB SSD, an X61 5G modem with eSIM, Wi-Fi 7 and a numeric keypad	High	[1][2]
T16 Gen 5 repairability is 10/10 on iFixit, the same as Framework. Keyboard replacement is "best-in-class", and Lenovo sells parts	High	[8][9]
Israel, 32 GB / 1 TB T16 Gen 5: from ₪9,687 (11 shops). No 16-inch business laptop is sold with 2 TB, so the 2 TB SSD (from ₪1,536) is an upgrade	Medium	[3][10][4]
The nearest 64 GB model in Israel is the ThinkPad P16s Gen 5 (64 GB / 1 TB) at ₪18,012–18,960. The Dell Pro 5 Series 16 (64 GB / 1 TB) is ₪13,894, but has no confirmed WWAN	Medium	[4][11]
US list price for a 32 GB / 1 TB T16 Gen 5 is $2,609, about ₪9,630 with 18% Israeli VAT, which is close to the Israeli price	Medium	[12][13][14]
Local ASR (Paraformer) needs no NPU: it runs at real-time factor 0.08–0.2 on 1–2 CPU threads. For local LLMs, memory bandwidth and RAM size matter, not NPU TOPS	Medium	[15][6]
eSIM on Linux is not guaranteed. Lenovo supports	Medium	[16]

Finding	Confidence	Sources
WWAN on Linux per module and per system, and eSIM support through ModemManager is reported as rough		
Framework Laptop 16 has QMK macro-pad modules but no cellular option, and no confirmed shipping to Israel	Low	[17][7]

3 Findings

3.1 The shortlist

The ThinkPad T16 Gen 5 is the only model whose spec sheet confirms every core requirement. The HP EliteBook 8 G1i 16 is the runner-up. I opened both Lenovo spec sheets myself on 2026-11-02 (PSREF, Lenovo's product specifications reference):

- **Intel version.** It has one LPCAMM2 slot taking up to 64 GB and one M.2 2280 PCIe 5.0 SSD of up to 2 TB [1].
- **AMD version (Ryzen AI PRO 400, "Gorgon Point").** It has two DDR5 SODIMM slots taking up to 96 GB, and up to 2 TB [2].
- **Both versions.** They list a "Snapdragon X61 5G Modem-RF System … with embedded eSIM functionality", a spill-resistant 6-row keyboard with a numeric keypad, Wi-Fi 7, a 5 MP camera, a dual-microphone array and an optional keyboard backlight [1][2].
- **US availability.** The Intel version is the only one sold in North America [18].

Model	RAM (max, type)	2 TB	5G eSIM	Notes	Verdict
ThinkPad T16 Gen 5 Intel	64 GB, 1× LPCAMM2	Yes	Yes (X61)	numpad; iFixit 10/10	**Basic pick**
ThinkPad T16 Gen 5 AMD	96 GB, 2× SODIMM	Yes	Yes (X61)	numpad; RAM upgradable	**Stretch pick, if sold in Israel**
ThinkPad P16s Gen 5 (AMD/Intel)	96 GB, LPCAMM2	Yes	Yes (X61)	stronger CPU/GPU; Ubuntu preload option	Stretch alternative, expensive
HP EliteBook 8 G1i 16	64 GB, 2× SODIMM	Yes	Yes (T700), at purchase only	backlit DuraKey keyboard	Runner-up
Dell Pro 16 Plus	32 GB with 5G (as shown)	not shown	Yes (tray)	64 GB + 5G not seen on Dell's store	Basic only

Model	RAM (max, type)	2 TB	5G eSIM	Notes	Verdict
ThinkPad P16 Gen 3	192 GB, 4× SODIMM	3 M.2 slots	Yes (RW350R)	2.54 kg workstation	Over-spec
Framework Laptop 16	96 GB, 2× SODIMM	2 M.2 slots	**None found**	QMK macro pad modules	Fails eSIM

Sources: [1][2][19][20][21][5][22][23].

No spec sheet shows 64 GB, 2 TB and 5G as one orderable SKU. Each appears as a separate option, so ordering all three together is inferred, not confirmed [1]. HP states that WWAN-ready hardware "must be selected at purchase" [5].

3.2 Compute for local AI on Linux

Any current 8–12-core Intel or AMD laptop CPU handles the ASR workload. RAM, not the NPU, decides what local agents can run. Paraformer int8 in sherpa-onnx runs at a real-time factor of 0.073–0.195 on one or two threads [15]. I found no Paraformer route on any NPU.

NPUs are usable on Linux, but only narrowly:

- **AMD.** AMD's Ryzen AI software supports only an NPU flow, only on Ubuntu 24.04 [24].
- **Intel.** Intel's NPU driver supports OpenVINO on Ubuntu 24.04 and 26.04 [25].
- **Snapdragon X2.** It is not ready for Ubuntu: Wi-Fi, audio and the webcam fail out of the box [26].

For local LLMs, token speed follows memory bandwidth. A community llama.cpp table shows Strix Halo at about twice Strix Point's text-generation speed on a 7B model: about 52–54 tokens/s against 22–24 [6]. That table is undated and doesn't give the test hardware. Strix Point/Gorgon Point and Panther Lake suit 7–14B models.

From those figures I infer that 32 GB is the floor. 64 GB is the practical size for 14–30B models alongside 4–8 Claude Code sessions and a VM.

Both T16 Gen 5 platforms run Ubuntu 26.04 well. Lenovo warns that WWAN may not work on Linux [27]. Its Linux WWAN enablement is per module and per system, and it requires ModemManager 1.22+ [16].

3.3 Macro keys, repairability and docking

Remap the T16's numeric keypad as macro keys. For dedicated keys, add a small QMK/VIA macro pad. The keypad is confirmed on both T16 Gen 5 spec sheets [1][2].

- **Remapping.** keyd remaps keys at the evdev level, so it works on both Wayland and X11, and it supports layers, tap/hold actions and macros [28]. Input Remapper is a GUI alternative packaged in Ubuntu [29]. Either covers PTT, retake, delete, send and a Claude Code key.
- **Framework.** It is the only laptop with built-in modular QMK macro keys [17], but it fails the eSIM requirement.

Repairability:

- **ThinkPad T16 Gen 5.** iFixit scored it 10/10 in 2026 [8]. iFixit also rates its keyboard replacement "best-in-class" and notes that Lenovo sells parts and publishes repair guides [9].
- **ThinkPad E series.** The E16, from the same family as the failed E15, has its keyboard bonded into the top case, which makes it harder to replace [9]. That fits the E15's history.
- **RAM prices.** RAM is expensive in late 2026: loose 32 GB DDR5 SODIMMs cost about $15–16.50 per GB, and prices rose 24% in six weeks [30]. Israeli 32 GB modules cost ₪1,589–2,444 [4]. A

second SODIMM slot (AMD T16) keeps a later upgrade cheap. The single LPCAMM2 slot (Intel T16) means replacing the module.

Docking:

- **Recommended docks.** The Dell WD22TB4 and the Lenovo 40B0 Thunderbolt 4 dock are the best documented on Linux, with fwupd firmware updates [31].
- **Display technologies.** MST docks need no driver. DisplayLink docks need the evdi module and don't work with proprietary GPU drivers [32].
- **AMD hosts.** No test covered an AMD laptop with Ethernet and two displays.

3.4 Prices and where to buy

Buy in Israel. The US saves little once VAT is paid, and it puts the warranty at risk.

Spec	Configuration (Israel, Zap, 2026-11-02, incl. VAT)	Cost
Basic	T16 Gen 5 21WT0061IV, Core Ultra 7 355, 32 GB / 1 TB, from ₪9,687–10,829, + Samsung 990 Pro 2 TB from ₪1,536	**₪11,200–12,400**
Stretch A (if the AMD T16 is sold here)	an AMD T16 Gen 5 32 GB configuration (price not found; assumed similar to Intel) + 32 GB SODIMM ₪1,589–2,444 + 2 TB SSD	**≈ ₪13,000–15,000 (inferred)**
Stretch B (available now)	P16s Gen 5 21XE005FIV, 64 GB / 1 TB, RTX PRO, ₪18,012–18,960, + 2 TB SSD	**₪19,500–20,500**
Stretch C (cheapest 64 GB)	Dell Pro 5 Series 16, 64 GB / 1 TB, ₪13,894 (WWAN not stated), + 2 TB SSD	**≈ ₪15,400**

Sources: [3][11][4].

- **Basic option with confirmed WWAN.** The ThinkPad T16 Gen 4 21QE0043IV (32 GB / 1 TB) is listed with 4G LTE, from ₪9,350 [3]. It is the only Israeli listing found that names a cellular modem.
- **US prices.** Lenovo US lists a 32 GB / 1 TB T16 Gen 5 at $2,609 [12]. That is ₪8,162 at 3.1284 ₪/$ [13], or ₪9,631 with 18% VAT [14]. The US and Israeli configurations differ, so no like-for-like saving was measured.
- **Warranty.** Lenovo's International Warranty Service covers a machine only where its machine type is sold and supported, and for the country-of-origin term, often one year in the US [33]. The Dell and HP evidence is forum-level.
- **Framework.** It had not launched in Israel as of the only source found (2023) [7].

4 Implications for this project

- `requirements.md`: I've added the options and price ranges above under a "Research outcome" heading. The tiers stay as recorded.

- **Budget line for the family budget:** ₪12,500 for the basic spec, ₪16,000 for the stretch spec.
- **Before ordering:**
  1. Ask the Lenovo Israel importer or reseller whether the SKU includes the X61 5G module, and whether a T16 Gen 5 AMD SKU is sold in Israel.
  2. Check the machine type on Lenovo's IWS lookup if buying abroad.
  3. Test the eSIM on Ubuntu early, inside the return window.

5 Open questions

- Does any Israeli T16 Gen 5 SKU include 5G/eSIM? Zap titles don't say [3].
- Is the T16 Gen 5 AMD sold in Israel, and at what price?
- What do KSP, Ivory and Bug charge? KSP blocked fetches, and Zap aggregates only part of the market.
- Is the US street price (with Lenovo coupons) meaningfully below list? There is no US egress to check it.
- Does an eSIM profile from an Israeli carrier work through ModemManager on this modem?
- Strix Halo laptops, for 30B+ local models, were not priced.

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